ABDUCTED

A social deduction game for 5–12 players, 15–25 minutes. Everyone knows which team you're on except you. *Some of you came back… different.*

BY DARREN DON



The goal. Score for your team, Human or Alien, by getting search parties to signal your way. The first team to 5 wins, and you win if the card in your stand shows that team when the game ends. The catch: your own card faces away from you.

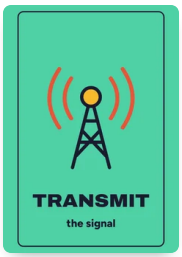
Components



10 Human cards
team cards



10 Alien cards
same back as the Humans



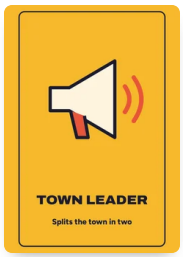
12 Transmit
signal cards



12 Jam
same back as Transmit



2 split cards
Party 1 and Party 2



Town Leader
and the Lookout

Also: 2 score counters (Humans and Aliens) and 12 plastic card stands.

Setup

1. Shuffle the 10 Human and 10 Alien cards together and deal one face down to each player. Without looking at it, put it in your stand so it **faces everyone else**. You can read every other player's card, never your own.

2. The rest of the team cards are the **deck**. Put it face down in the middle. Nobody knows what's in it.

3. Give everyone a Transmit and a Jam card.

4. Set both score counters to 0.

5. A random player takes the **Town Leader** card. The player across the table (halfway round, clockwise) takes the **Lookout** card.

The deck

With 5 players there are 15 cards in the deck; with 12, there are 8. The deck is always some mix of Humans and Aliens, so counting the cards you can see gets you close to knowing your team, never certain.

Table talk. Say anything, at any time: tell people what they are, lie, make deals, accuse. The one rule: never show anyone their own card.

Your card

The card in your stand is your team. It can change when the Lookout sends you to check out the light. Only the card in your stand at the end decides whether you win.

A round

1 Split

The Town Leader lays the two split cards on the table to cut the town into two parties, **Party 1** and **Party 2**, as evenly as possible. Each party is a run of neighbours. The town can't be split the same way as last round.



With 7 players, one party has 4 and the other 3.

2 Vote

On three, everyone except the Town Leader holds up **1 or 2 fingers**. The party with more votes goes out searching. The Town Leader breaks ties.

3 Signal

Each searcher secretly puts a card face down: **Transmit** if they think they're an Alien, **Jam** if they think they're Human. Shuffle and reveal them.

4 Score

The majority scores 1 for its team: Transmit for the Aliens, Jam for the Humans. On a tie, flip the deck's top card: its team scores. Put it back under the deck.

5 Check out that light

The Lookout points at one searcher (never themselves). That player looks at their own card and the deck's top card, mixes them face down, and puts one in their stand **without looking**. The other goes under the deck.

6 Pass

the Town Leader and Lookout cards clockwise. Start the next round.

Winning

The game ends the moment a team reaches **5**. Everyone takes their card out of its stand and looks at it. If your card shows the winning team, you win, along with everyone else on that team. It doesn't matter which signals you played.

What you know

You can see every card in a stand except yours, so you can count how many of each team are left for you and the deck. You see how everyone votes and how many Transmits and Jams each search party plays, but not who played which.

When you're sent to check out the light, you see two cards. If they match, you know your team. If they don't, it's a coin flip, and only you know that.

Why play one way

You want your team to score, so signal for the team you believe you're on. If you've got it wrong, you're scoring for the other side.

Everyone else knows what you are. Your teammates want you to know it; your opponents want you to believe the opposite. The Town Leader splits the town so the people they trust search together, and the Lookout sends the rival they'd most like to see flip.

Shorter or longer games

Play to **4** for a quick game, or **6** for a longer one.

Playing online? Abducted is playable in your browser at darrendon.com/games/abducted, with a tutorial, bots, and online tables you can join with a five-letter code.

Questions

Can the Lookout send themselves? No, always another searcher. The Lookout doesn't have to be in the search party to send someone.

Can I tell someone what their card is? Yes, truthfully or not. You just can't show them.

Does the Town Leader vote? Only to break a tie. If the Town Leader is in the search party, they signal like everyone else.

Does voting reveal anything? Only what each voter wants. Watch it: who wants which party out searching tells you who they trust, and what they think you are.